Chapter 2 — Basics: Types, Variables and Operators

Every Java program is built from the same small parts: **variables** that hold **values** of some **type**, **operators** that combine them, and **statements** that tell the computer what to do in order. This chapter covers those parts precisely — including the places where Java silently does something you might not expect (integer overflow, integer division, floating-point rounding, `==` on strings). It ends with text blocks, `String` basics and reading/writing the console.

What you'll learn

#	Topic	You will be able to…
2.1	Statements, identifiers, keywords, comments	read and name things legally
2.2	Variables	declare, initialise, scope and `final` variables
2.3	Primitive types	pick the right primitive and know its range
2.4	Literals	write numbers, characters and booleans in every legal form
2.5	Reference types and `null`	tell primitives from references
2.6	`var`	use local type inference well (and know its limits)
2.7	Conversions and casting	predict widening, narrowing, promotion and compound-assignment casts
2.8	Operators	use arithmetic, relational, logical, bitwise, ternary operators
2.9	Precedence and associativity	evaluate any expression by hand
2.10	Integer overflow	detect and prevent silent wrap-around
2.11	Floating point	explain `0.1 + 0.2`, NaN, infinity, and when to use `BigDecimal`
2.12	Strings and text blocks	use the core `String` operations and multi-line literals
2.13	Console output and input	`println` / `printf`, `Scanner`, `BufferedReader`, `Console`, `IO`

Code: `code/`, compiled with `javac --release 25`, output pasted from real runs. Exam-level traps on this material live in the OCP repo: Chapter 1 — Building Blocks (types, literals, `var`, text blocks, scope) and Chapter 2 — Operators (promotion, casting, precedence).

2.1 Statements, identifiers, keywords and comments

What it is

- A **statement** is one complete instruction, ending in `;` (e.g. `int x = 5;`). A **block** `{ … }` groups statements and can appear wherever a statement can.
- An **expression** is code that produces a value (`x + 1`, `name.length()`, `a > b`). An *expression statement* is an expression used as a statement (`x++;`, `print(...)`).
- An **identifier** is a name you choose for a variable, method, class or package.

Identifier rules

Rule	Legal	Illegal
Starts with a letter, `$` or `_`	`total`, `$price`, `_temp`	`2fast`
Then letters, digits, `$`, `_`	`item2`, `max_value`	`my-name`, `a b`
Not a reserved keyword or the literals `true`, `false`, `null`	`klass`, `clazz`	`class`, `null`
A single `_` is not an identifier (it is a keyword; see *unnamed variables*, Chapter 3)	`__`	`_`
Case-sensitive	`count` ≠ `Count`	—

Unicode letters are allowed (`größe`), and `$` is legal but by convention reserved for generated code.

Keywords

Java 25 has **51 reserved keywords** that can never be identifiers — e.g. `class`, `int`, `if`, `for`, `new`, `static`, `final`, `return`, `try`, plus `const` and `goto` (reserved but unused), `strictfp` (obsolete) and `_`. It also has **17 contextual keywords** that are keywords only in certain positions, so old code using them as names still compiles: `var`, `yield`, `record`, `sealed`, `non-sealed`, `permits`, `when`, and the module words `module`, `open`, `opens`, `exports`, `requires`, `transitive`, `uses`, `provides`, `to`, `with`. `true`, `false` and `null` are *literals*, not keywords, but are still unusable as names.

Comments

```
// line comment: to the end of the line
/* block comment:
   can span lines (cannot be nested) */
/** Javadoc comment: documents the next class, method or field. @param, @return tags… */
```

Write comments that explain **why**, not what the code already says.

2.2 Variables

What it is

A **variable** is a named storage location with a fixed **type**. Think of a labelled box: the label is the name, the box's shape (type) decides what may go in.

How it works

1. **Declare**: `type name;` — reserves the name and type.
2. **Initialise**: give it a first value (`name = value;`), often together: `int age = 30;`.
3. **Use/reassign**: read it in expressions, assign a new value of the same type.
4. The variable exists within its **scope** — the block `{ }` it was declared in, from the declaration to the closing brace.

`code/Variables.java`:

```java
static int counter;          // field: gets a default value (0) automatically

public static void main(String[] args) {
    int age;                 // declaration
    age = 30;                // initialisation (assignment)
    int year = 2025, month = 9;   // declare + initialise several of the same type
    age = age + 1;           // reassignment
    final double TAX_RATE = 0.18; // final: can be assigned exactly once
    // TAX_RATE = 0.2;       // compile error: cannot assign a value to final variable TAX_RATE

    System.out.println("age=" + age + " year=" + year + " month=" + month);
    System.out.println("TAX_RATE=" + TAX_RATE + " counter (field default)=" + counter);

    {                                // an inner block
        int inner = 5;               // exists only inside these braces
        System.out.println("inner=" + inner + ", age visible here too: " + age);
    }
    // System.out.println(inner);      // compile error: cannot find symbol

    int count;
    if (age > 18) count = 1; else count = 0;   // definitely assigned on every path
    System.out.println("count=" + count);
}
```

Output:

```
age=31 year=2025 month=9
TAX_RATE=0.18 counter (field default)=0
inner=5, age visible here too: 31
count=1
```

Local variables vs fields

	Local variable (inside a method/block)	Field (inside a class)
Default value	**None** — must be assigned before use, or compile error *"variable x might not have been initialized"*	Yes: `0`, `0.0`, `false`, `'\u0000'`, or `null` for references
Lifetime	Until the block ends	As long as the object (instance field) or class (`static` field)
Modifiers	Only `final`	Access modifiers, `static`, `final`, … (Chapter 5)

The compiler's **definite assignment** analysis checks that every path assigns a local before it is read — that is why `count` above compiles: both branches assign it.

`final`

`final` means *assigned once*. For a primitive, the value can never change; for a reference, the variable cannot point elsewhere but the **object itself can still change** (`final List<String> xs = new ArrayList<>(); xs.add("ok");` is legal). Use `final` for constants (`static final int MAX_RETRIES = 3;`) and wherever it clarifies intent.

Common mistakes

- Reading a local before assigning it in every branch.
- Redeclaring a name already in scope (`int x = 1; { int x = 2; }` is a compile error — locals cannot shadow locals).

- Thinking `final` makes an object immutable.

Self-check

1. Does `int n; System.out.println(n);` compile inside a method? → No — locals have no default value.
2. Can a `final List` have elements added? → Yes; only the reference is fixed.
3. What value does an uninitialised `boolean` field have? → `false`.

2.3 Primitive types

What it is

Java has exactly **eight primitive types** — simple values stored directly (not as objects). Everything else is a reference type (objects). Sizes and ranges are fixed by the language on every platform, unlike C.

`code/Primitives.java` prints the real values from the wrapper classes:

```
System.out.printf("%-8s %5d  %-22d %d%n", "int", Integer.SIZE, Integer.MIN_VALUE, Integer.MAX_VALUE);
// ... one line per type
```

Output:

```
type      bits  min                   max
byte         8  -128                  127
short       16  -32768                 32767
int         32  -2147483648            2147483647
long        64  -9223372036854775808   9223372036854775807
char        16  0                     65535
float       32  1.4E-45               3.4028235E38
double      64  4.9E-324              1.7976931348623157E308
boolean  true or false (size not specified by the language)
```

Type	Kind	Size	Range / precision	Default (fields)	Use it for
`byte`	signed integer	8 bits	−128 … 127	`0`	raw binary data, I/O buffers
`short`	signed integer	16 bits	−32 768 … 32 767	`0`	rarely — large arrays of small numbers
`int`	signed integer	32 bits	about ±2.1 billion (-2^{31} … $2^{31}-1$)	`0`	**the default integer** — counts, indexes
`long`	signed integer	64 bits	about $\pm 9.2 \times 10^{18}$	`0L`	timestamps (ms since 1970), IDs, money in cents, big counters
`float`	IEEE 754 binary floating point	32 bits	~6–7 significant decimal digits, up to $\pm 3.4 \times 10^{38}$	`0.0f`	graphics, large arrays where memory matters
`double`	IEEE 754 binary floating point	64 bits	~15–16 significant digits, up to $\pm 1.8 \times 10^{308}$	`0.0`	**the default decimal** — measurements, science
`char`	unsigned UTF-16 code unit	16 bits	`'\u0000'` … `'\uFFFF'` (0 … 65 535)	`'\u0000'`	single characters
`boolean`	logical	not specified	`true`, `false`	`false`	conditions, flags

Notes:

- `float`/`double` `MIN_VALUE` is the smallest **positive** value, not the most negative; the most negative is `-Double.MAX_VALUE`.
- A `char` is a UTF-16 *code unit*. Characters outside the Basic Multilingual Plane (many emoji) need two `char`s (a *surrogate pair*); see Chapter 7.
- `boolean` is not a number: `if (1)` does not compile, and you cannot cast between `boolean` and `int`.

Choosing a type

Need	Use
Whole numbers that fit in ±2 billion	`int`
Bigger whole numbers, epoch milliseconds, file sizes	`long`
Decimal measurements where tiny rounding is fine	`double`
Money, exact decimal arithmetic	`long` cents or `BigDecimal` — never `double` (2.11)
Arbitrary-size integers	`BigInteger` (Chapter 7)
Yes/no	`boolean`

Self-check

1. Largest `int`? → 2 147 483 647 (`Integer.MAX_VALUE`, $2^{31}-1$).
2. Is `char` signed? → No, it is unsigned 16-bit (0–65 535).
3. Why is `Double.MIN_VALUE` positive? → It is the smallest positive (subnormal) double, not the most negative.

2.4 Literals

What it is

A **literal** is a value written directly in source code. Its form decides its type.

`code/Literals.java`:

```
int decimal = 255, hex = 0xFF, octal = 0377, binary = 0b1111_1111;
long big = 9_000_000_000L;              // L suffix: needed beyond int range
float price = 19.99f;                   // f suffix: literal is double otherwise
double sci = 6.022e23, plain = 3.14;
char letter = 'A', unicode = 'é', tab = '\t';
boolean ready = true;
String text = "He said \"hi\"\\n";      // escaped quote and backslash

System.out.println(decimal + " " + hex + " " + octal + " " + binary);
System.out.println(big + " " + price + " " + sci + " " + plain);
System.out.println(letter + " " + unicode + " [" + tab + "] " + ready);
System.out.println(text);
System.out.println("char 'A' as a number: " + (int) letter + ", 'A' + 1 = " + (letter + 1)
        + ", (char) ('A' + 1) = " + (char) (letter + 1));
```

Output:

```
255 255 255 255
9000000000 19.99 6.022E23 3.14
A é [   ] true
He said "hi"\n
char 'A' as a number: 65, 'A' + 1 = 66, (char) ('A' + 1) = B
Integer.toBinaryString(10) = 1010, toHexString(255) = ff
```

Literal	Form	Type
Decimal integer	`42`, `1_000_000`	`int`
Long	`42L` (use capital `L`; `l` looks like `1`)	`long`
Hexadecimal	`0xFF`, `0xCAFE_BABE`	`int` (or `long` with `L`)
Octal	leading `0`: `0377` = 255	`int` — beware: `010` is **8**
Binary	`0b1010` (Java 7)	`int`
Floating point	`3.14`, `1e-9`, `.5`, `2.`	`double`
Float	`3.14f`	`float`
Character	`'A'`, `'\n'`, `'é'`	`char`
Boolean	`true`, `false`	`boolean`
String	`"text"`, text blocks `"""…"""`	`String`
Null	`null`	the null type (assignable to any reference)

Underscores (Java 7) may separate digits for readability — `1_000_000`, `0b1111_0000` — but not at the start or end of the digits, next to the decimal point, next to the `L`/`f` suffix, or directly after `0x`/`0b`.

Escape sequences in `char` and `String` literals: `\n` newline, `\t` tab, `\r` carriage return, `\b` backspace, `\f` form feed, `\"`, `\'`, `\\`, `\s` space (Java 15), octal `\0`–`\377`, and Unicode

`\uXXXX`.

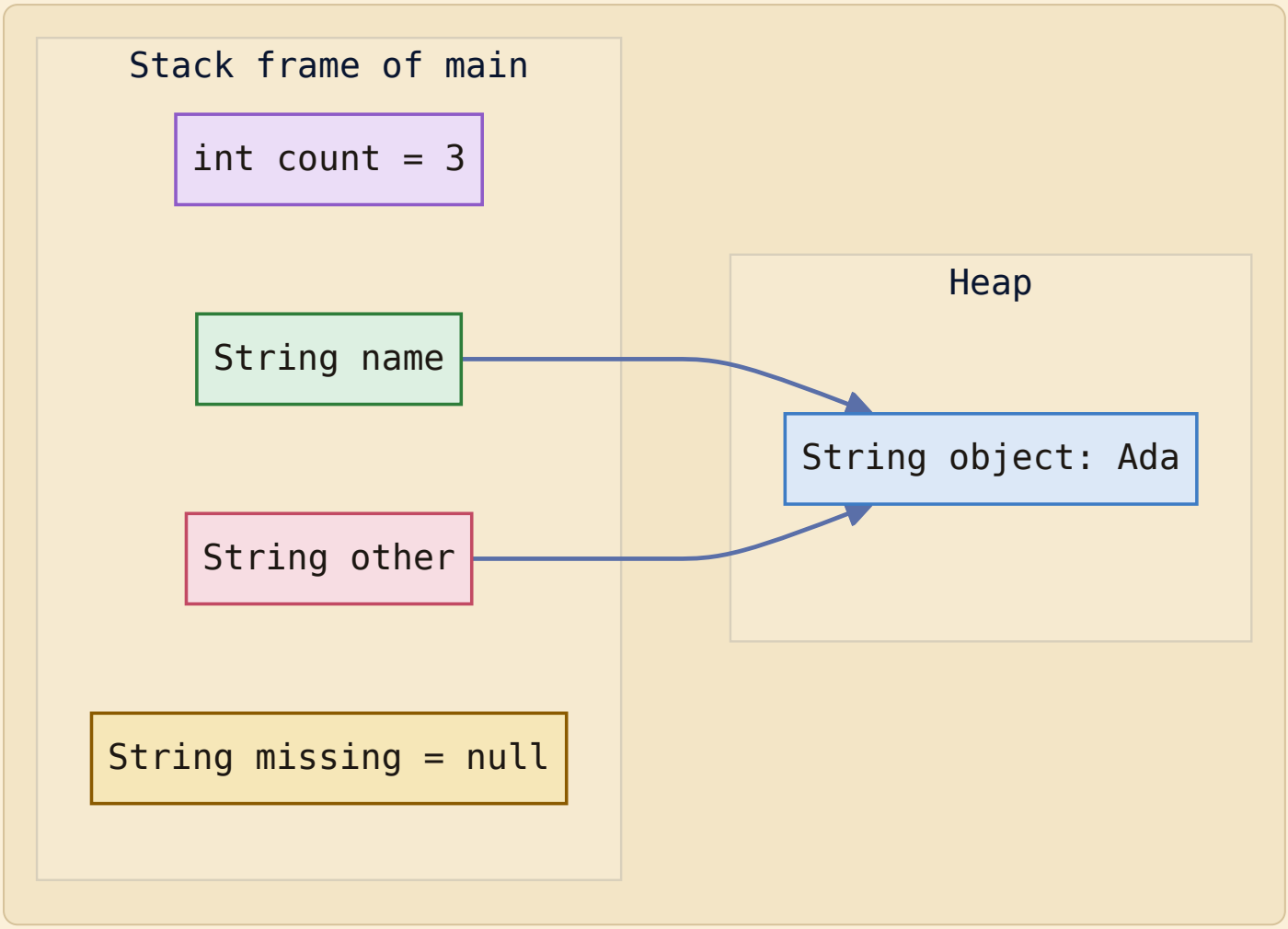
Common mistakes

- `long big = 9000000000;` → compile error *"integer number too large"*: the literal is an `int` until you add `L`.
- `float f = 1.5;` → compile error (*possible lossy conversion from double to float*); write `1.5f`.
- Leading zeros for alignment: `int code = 010;` is 8.

2.5 Reference types and `null`

What it is

Any type that is not one of the eight primitives is a **reference type**: classes (`String`, `Scanner`), interfaces (`List`), arrays (`int[]`), enums and records. A variable of a reference type holds a **reference** — a handle that points to an object on the heap (1.8) — or the special value `null`, meaning "points to nothing".



- Assigning a reference (`other = name`) copies the **arrow**, not the object: both variables now point to the same `String`.
- Calling a method through `null` throws `NullPointerException` at run time. Since Java 14 (JEP 358, on by default from Java 15), these *helpful NullPointerException* messages name exactly what was null, e.g. *Cannot invoke "String.length()" because "name" is null*.

	Primitive	Reference
Holds	the value itself	a pointer to an object, or `null`
Default (field)	`0` / `false` / `'\u0000'`	`null`
`==` compares	values	**identity** (same object?)
Has methods	no	yes (`name.length()`)
Name style	lowercase keyword (`int`)	a type name (`String`, `Integer`)

Every primitive has a **wrapper class** (`Integer`, `Double`, `Character`, `Boolean`…) so it can be used where an object is required, e.g. in `List<Integer>`. Java converts automatically (*autoboxing/unboxing*). The details — and the `Integer` cache trap — are in Chapter 7.

2.6 `var` — local variable type inference (Java 10)

What it is

`var` (Java 10, JEP 286) lets the compiler **infer** a local variable's type from its initialiser. The variable is still statically typed — the type is fixed at compile time; you just do not write it.

`code/VarDemo.java`:

```
var count = 10;                          // int
var ratio = 10 / 4.0;                    // double
var name = "Ada";                        // String
var scores = new HashMap<String, List<Integer>>();   // HashMap<String, List<Integer>>
scores.put(name, new ArrayList<>(List.of(90, 85)));
for (var entry : scores.entrySet()) {    // Map.Entry<String, List<Integer>>
    System.out.println(entry.getKey() + " -> " + entry.getValue());
}
// count = "ten";                        // compile error: the type is fixed at int
var items = new ArrayList<>();           // careful: ArrayList<Object>
items.add(1); items.add("two");
System.out.println(count + " " + ratio + " " + items);
```

Output:

```
Ada -> [90, 85]
10 2.5 [1, two]
{a=1}
```

Where `var` is allowed

Allowed	Not allowed
Local variables with an initialiser	Fields, method parameters, return types
`for` loop variables and for-each variables	Without initialiser: `var x;`
try-with-resources variables	`var x = null;` (no type to infer)
Lambda parameters (Java 11): `(var a, var b) -> a + b` — useful to add annotations	Array initialiser alone: `var a = {1, 2};`
	Multiple variables: `var a = 1, b = 2;`

`var` is a contextual keyword: `var var = 1;` compiles, but you cannot name a *type* `var`.

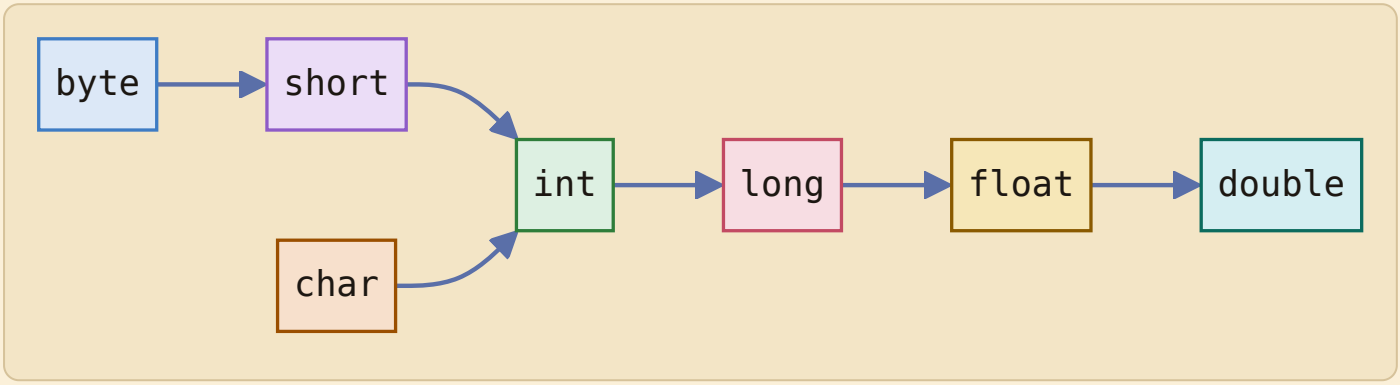
Trade-offs and style

Use `var` when the type is obvious from the right-hand side (`new`, a well-named factory) or long and noisy (generic types). Avoid it when the reader cannot see the type (`var result = service.process();`) or when the inferred type differs from what you want (`var list = new ArrayList<>()` becomes `ArrayList<Object>`; `var x = 1;` is `int`, not `long`). The OpenJDK team's *Local Variable Type Inference Style Guidelines* say the same: choose clarity for the reader.

2.7 Type conversion: widening, narrowing, casting, promotion

What it is

Converting a value from one type to another. Java does **safe** conversions automatically and requires an explicit **cast** — `(type) value` — for risky ones.



Arrows show **widening primitive conversions**, done automatically (`int i = 'A'; long l = i; double d = l;`). Going against the arrows is **narrowing** and needs a cast.

How it works

1. **Widening** (automatic): the target type can hold every value… *almost*. `int → float`, `long → float` and `long → double` can lose **precision** (not magnitude): a `float` has 24 bits of mantissa.
2. **Narrowing** (needs a cast): `(int) 3.99` truncates toward zero to `3`; `(byte) 300` keeps the low 8 bits (300 − 256 = 44). Floating → integer conversion clamps out-of-range values to MIN/MAX and turns NaN into 0.
3. **Numeric promotion** in expressions: before a binary arithmetic operator runs, `byte`, `short` and `char` operands become `int`; if either operand is `long`, `float` or `double`, both are converted to

the wider of these. So `byte + byte` is an `int`.

4. **Compile-time constants** may be assigned to a narrower type if they fit: `byte b = 10 + 20;` is fine; `byte b = x + y;` (variables) is not.
5. **Compound assignment** (`+=`, `-=`, `*=` …) includes a hidden cast: `x += 5` means `x = (T) (x + 5)` where `T` is `x`'s type.

`code/Conversions.java` (key lines):

```
double pi = 3.99;
int truncated = (int) pi;          // narrowing needs a cast; drops the fraction
long rounded = Math.round(pi);     // rounding is a method, not a cast

byte b = (byte) 300;               // keeps only the low 8 bits: 300 - 256 = 44
int precise = 123_456_789;
float f = precise;                 // widening but LOSSY: float has 24 bits of precision

byte x = 10, y = 20;
// byte sum = x + y;               // compile error: x + y is an int
byte sum = (byte) (x + y);
x += 5;                            // compound assignment hides a cast: x = (byte) (x + 5)

long wrong = 1_000_000 * 1_000_000;       // int overflow BEFORE widening to long
long right = 1_000_000L * 1_000_000;
```

Output:

```
widened: 100 100.0
(int) 3.99 = 3, Math.round(3.99) = 4
(byte) 300 = 44, (byte) 200 = -56
(int) 1e20 = 2147483647, (int) Double.NaN = 0
int 123456789 -> float -> int: 123456792
sum=30 sum2=30 x=15
constant=30 'a'+1=98 7/2=3 7/2.0=3.5
wrong=-727379968 right=1000000000000
```

The last line is the classic bug: the multiplication happens in `int` (both operands are `int`), overflows, and only then is the wrong result widened to `long`. Put `L` on the **first** operand.

Common mistakes

- Expecting `(int)` to round. It truncates toward zero: `(int) -3.99` is `-3`. Use `Math.round`, `Math.floor`, `Math.ceil`.
- `7 / 2` is `3`: both operands are `int`, so the division is integer division. Write `7 / 2.0` or `(double) 7 / 2`. Note `(double) (7 / 2)` is `3.0` — the cast came too late.
- Assuming widening is always lossless: `int → float` can change the value.

In the interview

Q: Why doesn't `short s = 1; s = s + 1;` compile, but `s += 1;` does? `s + 1` is promoted to `int`, and assigning an `int` to a `short` needs a cast. Compound assignment includes that cast implicitly.

- *What is `(byte) 200`?* −56: the low 8 bits `11001000` read as a signed byte.
- *Is `long → double` safe?* Magnitude yes, precision no: doubles have 53 bits of mantissa, longs 64.

Self-check

1. `char c = 'a'; c + 1` — type and value? → `int`, 98.
2. `(int) 7.9 + (int) -7.9` → 7 + (−7) = 0.
3. Fix `long ms = 24 * 60 * 60 * 1000 * 365;` → `24L * 60 * 60 * 1000 * 365`.

2.8 Operators

What it is

An **operator** is a symbol that computes a value from one (*unary*), two (*binary*) or three (*ternary*) operands.

Arithmetic: `+ - * / %` and `++ --`

`code/Arithmetic.java`:

```
System.out.println("17 / 5 = " + 17 / 5 + ", 17 % 5 = " + 17 % 5);
System.out.println("-17 / 5 = " + -17 / 5 + ", -17 % 5 = " + -17 % 5
        + ", Math.floorMod(-17, 5) = " + Math.floorMod(-17, 5));
System.out.println("17.0 / 5 = " + 17.0 / 5 + ", 5.5 % 2 = " + 5.5 % 2);
System.out.println("1.0 / 0 = " + 1.0 / 0 + ", 0.0 / 0 = " + 0.0 / 0);
try { System.out.println(1 / 0); }
catch (ArithmeticException e) { System.out.println("1 / 0 -> ArithmeticException: " + e.getMessage());
}

int a = 5;
int b = a++;     // post-increment: b gets the old value, then a becomes 6
int c = ++a;     // pre-increment: a becomes 7, then c gets 7
int n = 3;
int result = n++ + ++n;   // 3 + 5
```

Output:

```
17 / 5 = 3, 17 % 5 = 2
-17 / 5 = -3, -17 % 5 = -2, Math.floorMod(-17, 5) = 3
17.0 / 5 = 3.4, 5.5 % 2 = 1.5
1.0 / 0 = Infinity, 0.0 / 0 = NaN
1 / 0 -> ArithmeticException: / by zero
a=7 b=5 c=7
n++ + ++n with n=3 -> 8, n=5
compound ops -> x=1
-(-5) = 5, +3 = 3
```

Rule	Detail
Integer `/` truncates toward zero	`-17 / 5` is `-3`, not `-4`
`%` takes the sign of the **dividend**	`-17 % 5` is `-2`. For a always-non-negative result (e.g. circular buffers, "day of week"), use `Math.floorMod`
Integer division by zero	throws `ArithmeticException`
Floating division by zero	no exception: `Infinity`, `-Infinity` or `NaN`
`x++` vs `++x`	both add 1 to `x`; the *expression's value* is the old value (postfix) or the new value (prefix)
`+` with a `String` operand	means concatenation (2.12)

Style: use `++`/`--` as standalone statements (`i++;`). Expressions like `n++ + ++n` are legal and deterministic (Java evaluates operands left to right) but unreadable.

Assignment operators

`=`, and compound `+= -= *= /= %= &= |= ^= <<= >>= >>>=`. Assignment is itself an expression whose value is the assigned value, and it is right-associative: `a = b = c = 7` assigns 7 to all three.

Relational and equality: `< <= > >= == !=`, `instanceof`

All return `boolean`. For **primitives**, `==` compares values. For **references**, `==` compares **identity** — whether both sides point to the *same object*. To compare contents, call `equals`.

`code/Comparison.java`:

```
String s1 = "java";
String s2 = new String("java");
System.out.println("s1 == s2: " + (s1 == s2) + ", s1.equals(s2): " + s1.equals(s2));
```

Output:

```
s1 == s2: false, s1.equals(s2): true
```

`x instanceof Type` tests whether a reference points to an object of that type (false for `null`). The pattern form `x instanceof String s` is in Chapter 3.

Logical: `&& || !` and `& | ^`

Operator	Name	Evaluates right side?
`&&`	conditional AND	only if left is `true` (**short-circuit**)
`||`	conditional OR	only if left is `false` (short-circuit)
`!`	NOT	—
`&`, `|`	logical AND / OR on booleans	**always** both sides
`^`	XOR (exactly one true)	always both

```
static boolean check(String label, boolean value) {
    System.out.println("  evaluated " + label);
    return value;
}
boolean r1 = check("left", false) && check("right", true);
boolean r2 = check("left", false) & check("right", true);

String name = null;
if (name != null && name.length() > 3) System.out.println("long name");   // safe: && stops at null
```

Output:

```
&& short-circuits:
  evaluated left
& evaluates both:
  evaluated left
  evaluated right
r1=false r2=false true ^ true=false !true=false
null-safe check with && worked
```

Short-circuiting is what makes the *null guard* idiom `x != null && x.foo()` safe. With `&` it would throw `NullPointerException`.

Ternary `?:`

`condition ? valueIfTrue : valueIfFalse` is an **expression** (it produces a value), unlike `if`:

```
String category = age < 13 ? "child" : age < 20 ? "teen" : "adult";   // "adult" for 20
```

Keep it to one level; nested ternaries become a puzzle — use `if` or a `switch` expression (Chapter 3).

Bitwise and shift: `& | ^ ~ << >> >>>`

On integer types these work on individual bits. `code/Bitwise.java`:

```
static final int READ = 1, WRITE = 2, EXEC = 4;   // 001, 010, 100
int a = 0b1100, b = 0b1010;
System.out.println("a & b = " + bin(a & b) + ", a | b = " + bin(a | b)
        + ", a ^ b = " + bin(a ^ b) + ", ~a = " + (~a));
System.out.println("1 << 4 = " + (1 << 4) + ", 64 >> 2 = " + (64 >> 2));
System.out.println("-16 >> 2 = " + (-16 >> 2) + ", -16 >>> 28 = " + (-16 >>> 28));
int perms = READ | WRITE;                // set two flags
perms &= ~WRITE;                         // clear a flag
```

Output:

```
a & b = 1000, a | b = 1110, a ^ b = 110, ~a = -13
1 << 4 = 16, 64 >> 2 = 16
-16 >> 2 = -4, -16 >>> 28 = 15
1 << 32 = 1  (shift distance is taken mod 32 for int)
can write? true, can exec? false
after clearing WRITE: 1
is 12 even? true
```

Operator	Meaning	Example
`&`	1 where both bits are 1	mask/test a flag: `(perms & WRITE) != 0`
`|`	1 where either is 1	set a flag
`^`	1 where bits differ	toggle; `a ^ a == 0`
`~`	flip every bit; `~x == -x - 1`	clear with `& ~FLAG`
`<<`	shift left, fill with 0; `x << n` = $x \cdot 2^n$ (until overflow)	`1 << k` = k-th bit
`>>`	*arithmetic* shift right, copies the sign bit	`-16 >> 2 = -4`
`>>>`	*logical* shift right, fills with 0	unsigned view of negatives

The shift distance uses only the low 5 bits for `int` (6 for `long`), so `1 << 32 == 1`. Real uses: permission flags, hash functions (`HashMap` mixes `h ^ (h >>> 16)`), `EnumSet`'s bit vector, network protocols, and bit tricks in interviews (Chapter 19).

Self-check

1. `-7 / 2` and `-7 % 2`? → `-3` and `-1`.
2. Why is `if (s != null & s.isEmpty())` dangerous? → `&` evaluates both sides, so it throws when `s` is null.
3. `int x = 5; int y = x++ * 2;` → `y = 10`, `x = 6`.

4. Two strings print the same but `==` is false. Why? → They are different objects; use `equals`.

2.9 Operator precedence and associativity

What it is

Precedence decides which operator binds first (`*` before `+`); **associativity** decides the order among equal-precedence operators (most are left-to-right; assignment and the ternary are right-to-left). Operands themselves are always **evaluated left to right**.

Level (high → low)	Operators	Associativity
1 Postfix	`expr++` `expr--`	left
2 Unary	`++expr` `--expr` `+` `-` `~` `!` `(type)` cast	right
3 Multiplicative	`*` `/` `%`	left
4 Additive	`+` `-` (and string `+`)	left
5 Shift	`<<` `>>` `>>>`	left
6 Relational	`<` `>` `<=` `>=` `instanceof`	left
7 Equality	`==` `!=`	left
8 Bitwise AND	`&`	left
9 Bitwise XOR	`^`	left
10 Bitwise OR	`|`	left
11 Conditional AND	`&&`	left
12 Conditional OR	`||`	left
13 Ternary	`? :`	right
14 Assignment, lambda	`=` `+=` `-=` … `->`	right

`code/Precedence.java`:

```
System.out.println("2 + 3 * 4 = " + (2 + 3 * 4));
System.out.println("(2 + 3) * 4 = " + ((2 + 3) * 4));
System.out.println("10 - 4 - 3 = " + (10 - 4 - 3) + "  (left to right)");
int a, b, c;
a = b = c = 7;                                  // assignment is right-associative
System.out.println("a=" + a + " b=" + b + " c=" + c);
System.out.println(1 + 2 + "3" + 4 + 5);        // left to right: 3, then "33", "334", "3345"
System.out.println("true || false && false = " + (true || false && false));
int x = 6;
System.out.println("x & 1 == 0 needs parentheses: " + ((x & 1) == 0));
```

Output:

```
2 + 3 * 4 = 14
(2 + 3) * 4 = 20
10 - 4 - 3 = 3  (left to right)
a=7 b=7 c=7
3345
true || false && false = true
5 > 3 == true: true
x & 1 == 0 needs parentheses: true
```

- `&&` binds tighter than `||`, so `true || false && false` is `true || (false && false)`.
- `==` binds tighter than `&`, so `x & 1 == 0` means `x & (1 == 0)` — a compile error for `int x`. Always parenthesise bitwise tests.
- `+` is left-associative, so `1 + 2 + "3"` adds first, then concatenates.

Rule of thumb: remember "unary → multiplicative → additive → comparison → equality → logical → ternary → assignment", and add parentheses whenever a reader might hesitate.

2.10 Integer overflow

What it is

Integer arithmetic in Java is done modulo 2^{32} (`int`) or 2^{64} (`long`). When a result exceeds the range it silently **wraps around** — no exception, no warning. This is **overflow**.

Analogy: a car odometer with six digits rolls from 999 999 to 000 000.

Why it matters

Overflow bugs are real and expensive: the binary-search midpoint bug `(low + high) / 2` sat in the JDK's own `Arrays.binarySearch` for years (fixed in 2006), and timestamps multiplied in `int` produce negative durations.

`code/Overflow.java`:

```java
int max = Integer.MAX_VALUE;
System.out.println("MAX_VALUE + 1 = " + (max + 1));
System.out.println("Math.abs(Integer.MIN_VALUE) = " + Math.abs(Integer.MIN_VALUE));

int low = 2_000_000_000, high = 2_100_000_000;
System.out.println("(low + high) / 2 = " + (low + high) / 2 + "   <- overflow bug");
System.out.println("low + (high - low) / 2 = " + (low + (high - low) / 2));
System.out.println("(low + high) >>> 1 = " + ((low + high) >>> 1));

try { Math.addExact(max, 1); }
catch (ArithmeticException e) { System.out.println("Math.addExact(MAX, 1) -> " + e.getMessage()); }
long seconds = 30L * 24 * 60 * 60 * 1000;     // L on the first operand: all long math
```

Output:

```
MAX_VALUE + 1 = -2147483648
Math.abs(Integer.MIN_VALUE) = -2147483648
-Integer.MIN_VALUE = -2147483648
(low + high) / 2 = -97483648   <- overflow bug
low + (high - low) / 2 = 2050000000
(low + high) >>> 1 = 2050000000
Math.addExact(MAX, 1) -> integer overflow
Math.toIntExact(3e9) -> integer overflow
30 days in ms (long) = 2592000000, as int math = -1702967296
```

How to defend

Technique	Example
Use a wider type early	`long total = (long) a * b;` or `30L * …`
Throw instead of wrapping	`Math.addExact`, `subtractExact`, `multiplyExact`, `incrementExact`, `negateExact`, `toIntExact` (Java 8), `absExact` (Java 15)
Rearrange the formula	`low + (high - low) / 2`
Unlimited size	`BigInteger` (Chapter 7)

Note that `Math.abs(Integer.MIN_VALUE)` is still negative, because +2 147 483 648 does not fit in an `int`.

In the interview

Q: What happens when an `int` overflows in Java? It wraps around silently using two's-complement arithmetic (`MAX_VALUE + 1 == MIN_VALUE`). Use `long`, `Math.*Exact` methods (which throw `ArithmeticException`), or `BigInteger`.

- *Where have you seen overflow in practice?* Binary-search midpoints, hash-code arithmetic (intentional), millisecond calculations, summing large arrays of `int`.

2.11 Floating-point numbers

What it is

`float` and `double` follow **IEEE 754** binary floating point: a number is stored as sign × binary fraction (mantissa) × 2^exponent. Most decimal fractions (0.1, 0.2) have no exact binary form — just as 1/3 has no exact decimal form — so they are stored as the nearest representable value.

`code/FloatingPoint.java`:

```
System.out.println("0.1 + 0.2 = " + (0.1 + 0.2));
System.out.println("0.1 + 0.2 == 0.3: " + (0.1 + 0.2 == 0.3));
System.out.println("|diff| < 1e-9: " + (Math.abs((0.1 + 0.2) - 0.3) < 1e-9));
double nan = 0.0 / 0;
System.out.println("NaN == NaN: " + (nan == nan) + ", Double.isNaN: " + Double.isNaN(nan));
System.out.println("-0.0 == 0.0: " + (-0.0 == 0.0) + ", Double.compare(-0.0, 0.0): " +
Double.compare(-0.0, 0.0));
double total = 0;
for (int i = 0; i < 10; i++) total += 0.1;
BigDecimal exact = new BigDecimal("0.1").add(new BigDecimal("0.2"));
```

Output:

```
0.1 + 0.2 = 0.30000000000000004
0.1 + 0.2 == 0.3: false
|diff| < 1e-9: true
0.1f + 0.2f = 0.3
1.0 - 0.9 = 0.09999999999999998
NaN == NaN: false, Double.isNaN: true
-0.0 == 0.0: true, Double.compare(-0.0, 0.0): -1
1e308 * 10 = Infinity, Math.sqrt(-1) = NaN
16777217 as float = 1.6777216E7  (2^24 + 1 not representable)
0.1 added ten times = 0.9999999999999999
BigDecimal 0.1 + 0.2 = 0.3, new BigDecimal(0.1) =
0.1000000000000000055511151231257827021181583404541015625
Math.round(2.5)=3 Math.round(-2.5)=-2 Math.floor(-2.5)=-3.0 Math.ceil(-2.5)=-2.0
```

(`0.1f + 0.2f` *prints* as `0.3` only because `float`'s shorter printed form hides the error.)

Special values

Value	Produced by	Test with
`Infinity`, `-Infinity`	overflow (`1e308 * 10`), `1.0 / 0`	`Double.isInfinite(x)`
`NaN` (Not a Number)	`0.0 / 0`, `Math.sqrt(-1)`	`Double.isNaN(x)` — **never** `x == Double.NaN` (NaN is not equal to anything, even itself)
`-0.0`	`-1.0 / Double.POSITIVE_INFINITY`, rounding tiny negatives	equals `0.0` with `==`, but `Double.compare` and `Double.equals` distinguish it

How to handle it

1. **Compare with a tolerance**, not `==`: `Math.abs(a - b) < 1e-9` (choose the tolerance for your domain).
2. **Money**: use `long` minor units (cents) or `BigDecimal` constructed from a **`String`** (`new BigDecimal("0.1")`) or `BigDecimal.valueOf(0.1)` — `new BigDecimal(0.1)` captures the binary error exactly, as shown above.
3. **Rounding**: `Math.round` rounds half **up toward positive infinity** (`-2.5 → -2`); `Math.floor`/`ceil` return `double`. For decimal rounding modes (half-even, as banks use), use `BigDecimal.setScale`.
4. **Loops**: never use a `double` as a loop counter compared with `==` — after ten additions of 0.1 you have 0.9999999999999999, not 1.0.
5. Since Java 17 (JEP 306) all floating-point arithmetic is strict IEEE 754 on every platform, so results are reproducible; the `strictfp` modifier is obsolete.

In the interview

Q: Why is `0.1 + 0.2 != 0.3` in Java? 0.1 and 0.2 cannot be represented exactly in binary floating point; the stored approximations sum to 0.30000000000000004. Compare with a tolerance, or use `BigDecimal` for exact decimal arithmetic such as money.

- *How do you check for NaN?* `Double.isNaN(x)`; `x != x` also works because NaN is the only value not equal to itself.
- *Why not `new BigDecimal(0.1)`?* It converts the already-inexact double; use the String constructor or `BigDecimal.valueOf`.

Self-check

1. What does `1 / 0.0` give? And `1 / 0`? → `Infinity`; `ArithmeticException`.
2. Best type for a bank balance? → `BigDecimal` (or `long` cents).

3. `Math.round(-0.5)`? → `0`.

2.12 Strings and text blocks

What it is

A **`String`** is an object holding an immutable sequence of characters. It is a reference type with special support: literals (`"hi"`), the `+` concatenation operator, and a pool of shared literals. This section covers what you need for the next chapters; the full API, `StringBuilder` and formatting in depth are in Chapter 7.

`code/StringBasics.java`:

```
String message = "Hello" + ", " + "Ada" + "!";
System.out.println(message + " length=" + message.length());
System.out.println("charAt(0)=" + message.charAt(0) + " indexOf(\"Ada\")=" + message.indexOf("Ada")
        + " substring(7, 10)=" + message.substring(7, 10));

String s = "java";
s.toUpperCase();                        // result thrown away: Strings are immutable
System.out.println("after s.toUpperCase(): " + s);
s = s.toUpperCase();                    // reassign the variable to the new String
System.out.println("after s = s.toUpperCase(): " + s);

String a = "hi", b = "hi", c = new String("hi");
System.out.println("a == b: " + (a == b) + " (same pooled literal), a == c: " + (a == c)
        + ", a.equals(c): " + a.equals(c) + ", \"HI\".equalsIgnoreCase(a): " +
"HI".equalsIgnoreCase(a));
System.out.println("String.valueOf(42) + 1 = " + String.valueOf(42) + 1
        + ", Integer.parseInt(\"42\") + 1 = " + (Integer.parseInt("42") + 1));
System.out.println("'a' + 'b' = " + ('a' + 'b') + ", \"\" + 'a' + 'b' = " + ("" + 'a' + 'b'));
```

Output:

```
Hello, Ada! length=11
charAt(0)=H indexOf("Ada")=7 substring(7, 10)=Ada
upper=HELLO, ADA! contains Ada? true
after s.toUpperCase(): java
after s = s.toUpperCase(): JAVA
a == b: true (same pooled literal), a == c: false, a.equals(c): true, "HI".equalsIgnoreCase(a): true
compareTo: -1, isBlank: true, strip: [pad], repeat: abababab
String.valueOf(42) + 1 = 421, Integer.parseInt("42") + 1 = 43
'a' + 'b' = 195, "" + 'a' + 'b' = ab
null concatenated: null
```

Key facts

Fact	Consequence
Immutable — no method changes a `String`	Methods return a *new* string; assign the result. Safe to share between threads and as `HashMap` keys.
String pool — identical literals share one object	`"hi" == "hi"` is `true`, but `new String("hi")` makes a distinct object. Never rely on `==`; use `equals`.
Indexes are **0-based**; `substring(begin, end)` excludes `end`	`"Hello".substring(1, 3)` is `"el"`; out-of-range throws `StringIndexOutOfBoundsException`.
`+` with any `String` operand concatenates	Numbers are converted with `String.valueOf`; `null` becomes `"null"`. Adding two `char`s is **numeric** (`'a' + 'b' == 195`).
Concatenating in a loop creates many objects	Use `StringBuilder` in loops (Chapter 7).
Converting	`String.valueOf(x)` / `"" + x` to text; `Integer.parseInt`, `Double.parseDouble` from text (throw `NumberFormatException` on bad input).

Most-used methods (Java version for newer ones): `length`, `charAt`, `indexOf`, `substring`, `contains`, `startsWith`/`endsWith`, `toUpperCase`/`toLowerCase`, `trim`, `strip` (11), `isEmpty`, `isBlank` (11), `repeat` (11), `lines` (11), `replace`, `split`, `equals`, `equalsIgnoreCase`, `compareTo`, `String.join`, `formatted` (15).

Text blocks (Java 15)

A **text block** (JEP 378, final in Java 15) is a multi-line string literal opened by `"""` followed by a line break and closed by `"""`. It is still an ordinary `String`.

`code/TextBlocks.java`:

```
String json = """
        {
          "name": "Ada",
          "langs": ["Java", "SQL"]
        }
        """;
System.out.print(json);

String sql = """
    SELECT id, name
    FROM users
    WHERE active = true\
    """;                                    // \ at line end: no newline there
System.out.println("[" + sql + "]");

String spaces = """
    trailing kept:\s
    quote: \""" inside
    """;
System.out.print(spaces.replace(' ', '.'));

String html = """
    <p>Hello, %s!</p>
    """.formatted("World");
```

Output:

```
{
  "name": "Ada",
  "langs": ["Java", "SQL"]
}
[SELECT id, name
FROM users
WHERE active = true]
trailing.kept:.
quote:.""".inside
<p>Hello, World!</p>
lines in json: 4
```

How the compiler processes a text block:

1. The content starts on the line **after** the opening `"""` (text on the same line is a compile error).
2. **Incidental indentation** is removed: the compiler finds the smallest indentation among non-blank lines *and the closing `"""` line*, and strips that much from every line. Move the closing delimiter left to keep more indentation.
3. Trailing spaces on each line are stripped; line endings become `\n` whatever the OS.
4. Escapes are processed last. Two escapes were added for text blocks: `\<line-end>` joins lines (no newline), and `\s` is a single space that survives stripping.
5. If the closing `"""` is on its own line, the string ends with `\n`; if it follows text directly, it doesn't.

Use text blocks for embedded SQL, JSON, HTML and test fixtures. For exam-level indentation traps, see the OCP repo's text blocks section.

Common mistakes

- `if (input == "yes")` — compares identity; use `"yes".equals(input)` (also null-safe).
- Calling `s.trim();` without assigning the result.
- `"Total: " + a + b` when `a`, `b` are numbers → concatenates both (`"Total: 12"`); write `"Total: " + (a + b)`.

Self-check

1. `"abc".substring(1)`? → `"bc"`.
2. Why is `"yes".equals(input)` better than `input.equals("yes")`? → It does not throw if `input` is `null`.
3. Does a text block with the closing `"""` on its own line end with a newline? → Yes.

2.13 Console output and input

Output: `print`, `println`, `printf`

`System.out` is a `PrintStream` connected to **standard output**; `System.err` to **standard error** (a separate stream, shown in red by many IDEs, useful for diagnostics that should not mix with data output).

`code/Formatting.java`:

```java
System.out.print("print has no newline; ");
System.out.println("println adds one.");
System.out.printf("%-10s|%5d|%8.2f|%n", "Coffee", 3, 4.5);
System.out.printf("%-10s|%05d|%8.3e|%n", "Padded", 42, 12345.678);
System.out.printf("%s %b %c %x %o %%%n", "str", true, 'J', 255, 8);
System.out.printf(Locale.GERMANY, "German: %,.2f%n", 1234567.891);
System.out.printf(Locale.US, "US:     %,.2f%n", 1234567.891);
String line = String.format("Total: %.2f", qty * price);
String line2 = "Items: %d".formatted(qty);         // Java 15
System.err.println("(this line goes to standard error)");
```

Output:

```
print has no newline; println adds one.
Coffee    |    3|    4.50|
Padded    |00042|1.235e+04|
str true J ff 10 %
German: 1.234.567,89
US:     1,234,567.89
Total: 13.50 / Items: 3
(this line goes to standard error)
```

Specifier	Meaning	Flags/width examples
`%s`	any value via `toString()`	`%-10s` left-align in 10 chars
`%d`	integer (`int`, `long`, `BigInteger`)	`%5d` width 5, `%05d` zero-pad, `%,d` grouping
`%f`, `%e`	decimal, scientific	`%.2f` two decimals (rounds half-up)
`%b`, `%c`	boolean, char	
`%x`, `%o`	hex, octal	`%08X`
`%n`	platform line separator	prefer over `\n` in `printf`
`%%`	a literal `%`	

Formatting is **locale-sensitive**: the default locale decides the decimal and grouping separators, which is why tests and machine-readable output should pass an explicit `Locale` (e.g. `Locale.ROOT` or `Locale.US`). A mismatched type (`%d` with a `double`) throws `IllegalFormatConversionException` at run time.

Input: four options

Option	Best for	Notes
`Scanner` (`java.util`)	Beginner programs, parsing numbers and words	Tokenises input by whitespace; `nextInt`, `nextDouble`, `next`, `nextLine`, `hasNextInt`… Slow for very large input.
`IO.readln(prompt)` (`java.lang.IO`, **Java 25**)	Simplest line input	Returns a line as `String` (or `null` at end of input); pairs with `IO.println`.
`BufferedReader` over `InputStreamReader(System.in)`	Fast line-by-line reading (competitive programming, large input)	`readLine()` returns `null` at end; you parse numbers yourself; throws `IOException`.
`System.console()` → `java.io.Console`	Passwords (`readPassword` does not echo)	Returns `null` when there is no interactive terminal (IDE consoles, redirected input) — always check.

Pick one reader per program. Each of them buffers `System.in`; if a `Scanner` reads ahead, a `BufferedReader` created later will not see that input.

Deterministic `Scanner` demo reading from a `String` (`code/ScannerDemo.java`) — a real program would use `new Scanner(System.in)`:

```
String fakeKeyboard = """
        Ada Lovelace
        36
        1.5 2.5 3.0
        done
        """;
Scanner in = new Scanner(fakeKeyboard);
String fullName = in.nextLine();          // whole line
int age = in.nextInt();                   // one token -> int
in.nextLine();                            // consume the rest of the "36" line!
double sum = 0;
while (in.hasNextDouble()) sum += in.nextDouble();
String word = in.next();                  // next token

Scanner trap = new Scanner("42\nAlan Turing\n");
int n = trap.nextInt();
String afterInt = trap.nextLine();        // returns the EMPTY rest of the first line

Scanner bad = new Scanner("forty-two");
if (!bad.hasNextInt()) System.out.println("not an int: " + bad.next());
```

Output:

```
name=Ada Lovelace, age=36, sum=7.0, word=done
n=42, nextLine after nextInt=[], then=[Alan Turing]
not an int: forty-two
```

The `nextInt` + `nextLine` trap: `nextInt()` reads the number but leaves the line break; the following `nextLine()` returns the empty remainder of that line. Call an extra `nextLine()` after `nextInt()` (as above), or read every line with `nextLine()` and parse with `Integer.parseInt`. Calling `nextInt()` on non-numeric input throws `InputMismatchException` — guard with `hasNextInt()`.

The interactive version, `code/Interactive.java`, takes the reading style as an argument (`java -cp out ch02.io.Interactive scanner|io|reader|console`). Key part and a real run with the `console` mode in a

terminal:

```
Console console = System.console();          // null if not an interactive terminal
if (console == null) {
    System.out.println("No interactive console (IDE or redirected input).");
    return;
}
char[] secret = console.readPassword("Password (not echoed): ");
if (secret == null) return;                  // end of input (Ctrl+D)
System.out.println("Password length: " + secret.length);
Arrays.fill(secret, ' ');                    // wipe it from memory
```

```
Password (not echoed):
Password length: 7
```

With input redirected (`… console < file.txt`) it prints `No interactive console (IDE or redirected input).` Passwords are returned as `char[]`, not `String`, so you can wipe them (a `String` stays in memory until garbage-collected). (In JDK 22–24 `System.console()` could return a `Console` even when redirected; JDK 25 returns to the older default, and JDK 26 made `null` the rule whenever input or output is redirected.)

`java.lang.IO` also works in ordinary classes (`code/IOClassDemo.java`):

```
IO.print("IO.print, ");
IO.println("IO.println");
IO.println(42);
IO.println();
IO.println("done");
```

Output:

```
IO.print, IO.println
42

done
```

Command-line arguments (`String[] args`) are the other common input channel — see Chapter 4.

Self-check

1. After `int n = sc.nextInt();` the user's next line is skipped. Why and how to fix? → `nextInt` left the newline; call `sc.nextLine()` once, or read lines and parse.
2. Why is `readPassword` a `char[]`? → So it can be overwritten after use.
3. `System.console()` returns `null` in your IDE. Bug? → No; there is no interactive terminal. Handle `null`.

Chapter TL;DR

- Eight primitives: `byte short int long` (8/16/32/64-bit signed), `float double` (IEEE 754), `char` (16-bit unsigned UTF-16 unit), `boolean`. Everything else is a reference (or `null`).
- Locals must be assigned before use; fields get defaults. `final` = assign once (the object can still change). `var` (Java 10) infers local types; the type is still fixed.
- Literals: `L` for long, `f` for float, `0x`/`0b`/leading-`0` for hex/binary/octal, `_` separators.

- Widening is automatic (but `int/long → float` can lose precision); narrowing needs a cast and truncates/wraps. `byte/short/char` promote to `int` in arithmetic; compound assignment hides a cast.
- Integer `/` truncates; `%` follows the dividend's sign (`Math.floorMod` otherwise); integer `/0` throws, floating `/0` gives Infinity/NaN.
- `&&`/`||` short-circuit; `&`/`|` do not. `==` on references compares identity — use `equals` for content.
- Precedence: unary → `* / %` → `+ -` → shifts → relational → equality → `&` `^` `|` → `&&` → `||` → `?:` → assignment. Parenthesise when in doubt.
- Overflow wraps silently: use `long`, `Math.*Exact`, or `BigInteger`. Floating point is approximate: compare with tolerance; money in `BigDecimal`/cents.
- `String` is immutable and pooled; text blocks (Java 15) for multi-line literals with incidental-indentation stripping.
- Output with `println`/`printf` (locale-aware); input with `Scanner` (mind the `nextLine` trap), `IO.readln` (Java 25), `BufferedReader`, or `Console` for passwords — one reader per program.
- Exam-trap depth: OCP Chapter 1, OCP Chapter 2. Next: Chapter 3 — Control flow.